

HEMANT MISHRA

THE NEXT 100 INHERITORS

Weaving Magic

LAVANYA NALLI, 37

Vice-chairman, Nalli Chennai

Lavanya Nalli is the first woman in her family to join the 90-year-old legacy sari business. An engineer by training, she started her career at Nalli in 2005 and worked there for four years before moving to the US to do her MBA at Harvard Business School. She worked as a consultant with McKinsey in Chicago and as vice-president at Myntra before returning to Nalli on the condition that she will be given complete autonomy to build the brand's e-commerce venture.

Since then, the e-commerce vertical, launched in 2015, has grown manifold (300 per cent in the Covid year, FY2021). A big believer in keeping the luxury of handcrafted weaves within the reach of every woman, she talks about Nalli keeping very low margins but banking on volumes to drive business growth. On her part in the business, she says, "The greatest acknowledgement is success itself. After five years, I will be funding my own business." Besides building the e-commerce side of Nalli, she is also bringing in digital prints on satin, reviving old designs, and bringing in fabrics such as organza and tussars. On working with father Ramnath Nalli, she says a clear demarcation of roles helps. And while her father is a "brutally" tough coach, Lavanya feels it has helped her push herself further. ■

–Shwweta Punj

STORY TELLER When in her 20s, she wrote three books for children as Lavanya R.N.

"I joined Nalli almost accidentally. I had a month left after my IT engineering internship, so I joined the company"